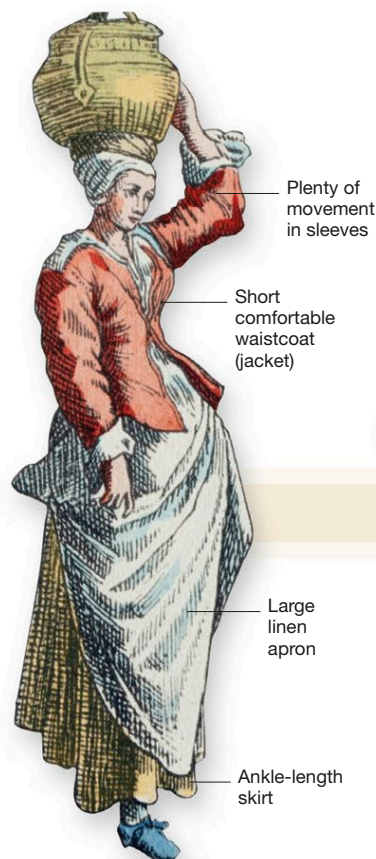


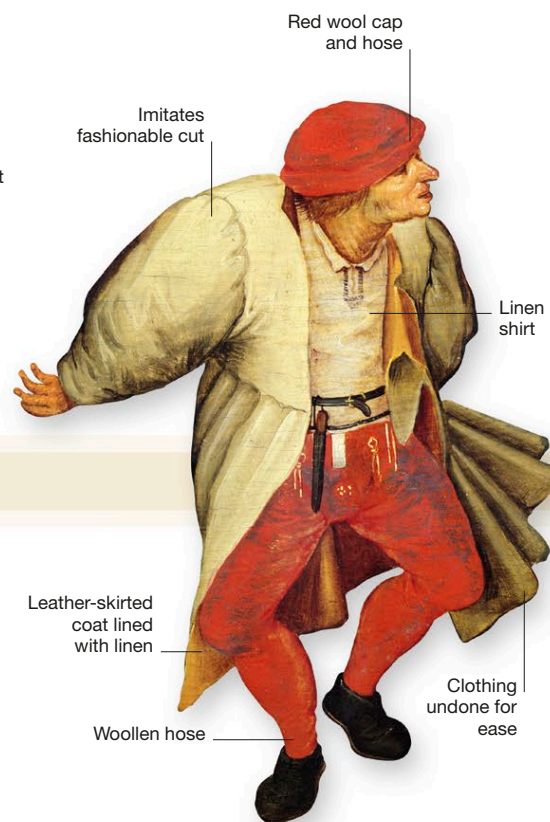
1450–1624

PRACTICAL CLOTHING

Renaissance fashion, for the rich, was a riot of silks, velvets, and jewels. However, for the vast majority – peasants working the land, traders, or part of the growing class of the “middling sort” including merchants and landed gentry – garments tended to be less fitted and exaggerated, and better suited to daily life. Linen and wool were staple fabrics – wool could be spun and woven at home. Silk was a rare luxury. As in any era people wore the best they could afford. Subtle hierarchies of cloth qualities were used to distinguish between coarse, sturdy everyday wear and finer, best garments. Producing fabric was labour intensive, so leaving out the expense and time of dyeing made sense. Clothing styles for the ordinary people changed over time, but slowly, as garments were replaced less often.



Waistcoat and petticoat This French peasant from the early 17th century wears a comfortable, practical outfit. She uses linen garments like her shirt and apron to protect her skirt. The thick linen scarf or cap helps stabilize the jar.



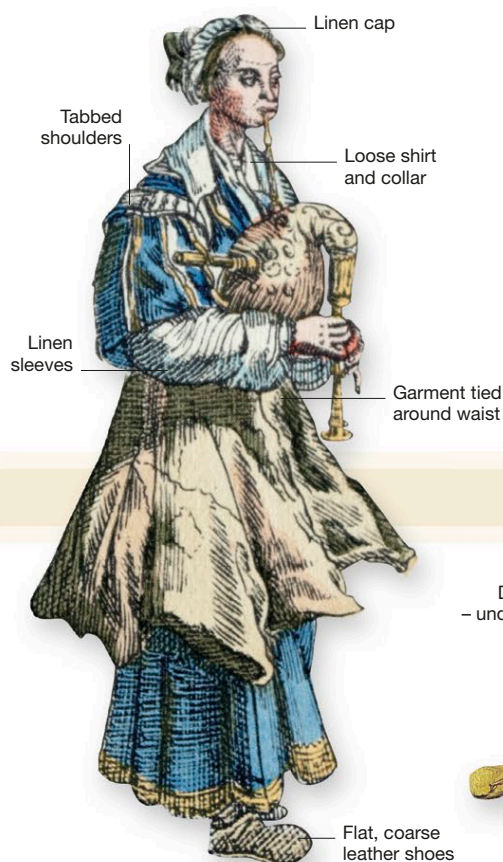
Occasion wear Bruegel's cheerful dancing man wears his best red cap and hose for a special occasion. He is dressed in fewer pieces of clothing than nobility, but the cut is not radically different.

USEFUL FABRICS



Leather jerkin

Leather was a practical choice because it was tough, protective, and needed little stitching. Aside from shoes, leather was used for aprons, purses, doublets, coats, and jerkins, like this late 16th-century example for a young man. This jerkin has been pinked and cut with star shapes for embellishment and to make it more flexible. Strong woollen fabrics were also popular, often left in their natural colour.



Following fashion Musicians wore more fashionable costume than peasants. The tabbed shoulders and paned sleeves of this musician's gown reflect early 17th-century French fashion.



Poor clothing The ageing “Everyman” from a painting by Bosch of 1515 wears a drab coat and wrinkled torn hose, with a black doublet and hood, and a travelling basket. His shoes are typical ankle boots fitting the foot's shape.